Achieving Universal Enrollment and Improving Learning Outcomes

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ASPIRE INDIA

ASPIRE is a registered non-profit organization in India, working towards making education inclusive, socially relevant, and keeping pace with the 21st-century challenges. It is a people's movement to ensure all children have the best possible learning opportunities and complete secondary schooling through a revitalized government school system.

GLOSSARY

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BLI		Bridge Language Inventory
CLFZ		Child Labor Free Zone
ESP		Education Signature Program
GPE		Global Partner Experience
GPs		Gram Panchayats
i-Lab		Integration Lab
LEP		Learning Enrichment Program
NRBC		Non-Residential Bridge Courses
PRI		Panchayati Raj Institution
RBC		Residential Bridge Courses
RTE		Right to Education
SMC		School Management Committees
SDP		School Development Plans
TLM		Teaching-Learning Materials
VER		Village Education Registers

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PREFACE

PREFACE

This deliverable set presents the findings of a qualitative multi-level multi-case study, where supervisors and local stakeholders were targeted across six selected panchayats, assessing the key enablers and barriers that explain the variation in achieving and sustaining Universal School Enrollment and Improving Learning Outcomes in the Keonjhar District, Odisha State, India.

In partnership with ASPIRE-India and the Integration Lab (i-Lab) at the University of Notre Dame, this research aims to provide evidence-based insights into the differential performance of panchayats and the contextual factors influencing the success of ASPIRE's education intervention.

The deliverable consists of two main elements:

I. **Research Report (this document)**: A comprehensive, 37-page, single-spaced technical document that details the project design, implementation, fieldwork conducted during the summer, the full synthesis and analysis of the findings, and recommendations.

II. **Policy Brief:** A concise, 3-page, short-form brief that entails an executive summary, key findings, and actionable recommendations.

These deliverables are expected to serve the following audiences:

I. **Primary audience**: ASPIRE Coordination/Management involved in the implementation of the ASPIRE Education Signature Program (ESP) in Keonjhar District. They can consult the Research Report for detailed insights into the program's effectiveness, local institutional dynamics, and recommendations for fine-tuning ongoing and future programs. The Policy Brief provides quick takeaways for management-level staff.

II. **Secondary audience**: Other education, development, and policy actors, especially those focused on strengthening rural education and local governance in India. They can similarly review the Policy Brief and consult the Research Report to access key findings and incorporate recommendations into their work.

III. **Tertiary audience:** Government officials and policymakers in the Odisha State administration can use the Policy Brief to quickly grasp core challenges, key findings, and evidence-based recommendations relevant to Universal Enrollment and learning targets.

About the Authors

This document was authored by a team of graduate students enrolled in the Integration Lab (i-Lab) in the Keough School of Global Affairs (KSGA) at the University of Notre Dame. This document assembles data, analyses, recommendations or guidance at the request of ASPIRE India. As the product of an academic experience, any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed herein are those of the student authors and do not necessarily reflect the views of the Keough School of Global Affairs, the University of Notre Dame or ASPIRE India.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

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The Integration Lab (i-Lab) at the University of Notre Dame and ASPIRE conducted this project to identify and address the key enablers and barriers that explain variation in the establishment and sustenance of Universal School Enrollment and Improving Learning Outcomes in Keonjhar District, Odisha, India. Despite progress in education, India still faces high dropout rates, poor infrastructure, and limited institutional support. ASPIRE's model addresses these challenges through a comprehensive strategy focused on access, learning, and governance.

Key informant interviews were used to uncover barriers and enabling factors for achieving Universal Enrollment and Improving Learning Outcomes in Keonjhar District. This design allows for the exploration of contextual and implementation factors that influence educational achievement. Furthermore, it is important to highlight the impressive results of ASPIRE's programs in affecting universal enrollment and improved learning outcomes at scale in the region. The aim of this study, however, is to explore sources of variability so as to enable continued improvement and the capacity to optimally serve the needs of all communities and students.

The data suggests that the variation across panchayats, in response to ASPIRE's program, seems to be driven by social, economic, and institutional disparities. Communities with greater socioeconomic stability and stronger local leadership tend to achieve better educational outcomes, while poorer or more remote areas face persistent challenges related to poverty, migration, and child labor. Entrenched social hierarchies and limited awareness continue to reproduce exclusion, although ASPIRE's community-based campaigns are gradually transforming attitudes toward education. Local governance, school leadership, and Learning Enrichment Program (LEP) coverage influence program success, fostering accountability and improved learning were implemented effectively. Broader structural factors, such as remoteness, language barriers, and shortages of trained teachers, further exacerbate inequality. At the individual level, age, caste, and household economic pressures continue to shape children's access and educational attainment.

Findings were used to propose evidence-based interventions and policy recommendations to strengthen ASPIRE's ongoing initiatives and contribute to broader discussions on educational governance and equity in India and similar global contexts.

1. INTRODUCTION

1. INTRODUCTION

Education is widely recognized as a fundamental pillar for societal development and equity. Achieving universal enrollment and high academic performance remains elusive. Global education data demonstrate that inequalities in accessing education have not improved since the pandemic. UNESCO data (2023) shows that the global number of out-of-school children has risen by 6 million since 2021 and now totals 250 million. Furthermore, the figures, compiled by the Global Education Monitoring Report and the UNESCO Institute for Statistics, reveal that education progress continues to stagnate globally (UNESCO, 2023). The result indicates that millions of children, especially in the Global South, remain excluded from formal learning opportunities.

The situation in India mirrors this global stagnation. In India, 5 percent of primary school-aged children are not enrolled in school. Children who are out of school are regarded as being below the minimum proficiency level. This is 4 percentage points lower (better) than the average for South Asia (SAR) and 3 percentage points lower (better) than the average for lower middle income (LMC) countries (World Bank, 2024) Improving access to education and academic achievement is essential because India will have the highest population of young people in the world over the next decade, and high-quality educational opportunities will determine the country's future (Government of India, 2020). Ensuring equitable access for this generation is critical to converting the demographic opportunity into long-term development.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

Parental Social Attitudes towards Education and Level of Education

Trying to understand the many factors associated with school dropouts in India, it was found that only 75% of the children in the age group 6 to 16 years were attending school, about 14% of the children never attended school, and 11% dropped out of school for a diverse set of reasons. Parental characteristics played a significant role in determining school education; thus, dropouts among children with illiterate parents were four times higher than those with literate parents. Uninterest in education, economic factors, and domestic or formal labor were also reasons among the households where the dropout was observed (Gouda and Sekher, 2014). Societal attitudes hampering children's attendance inhibit learning, as staying at home does not offer the learning conditions that can be found in a school under the guidance of a teacher.

Specifically, the parents' level of education plays an important role in reducing the school dropout rate and child labor incidence tendencies, noting that higher educated parents provide an adequate environment, which facilitates their children's opportunities for educational attainment (Barman, 2010). Hence, there is a positive relationship between parental education, especially the mother's education, and the educational attainment of children, the latter being the most important factor when it comes to avoiding manual work incidents, which supports the notion that women's educational level can increase parental awareness (Mukherjee and Das, 2008). Social attitudes not only impact attendance, as having someone that is engaged and more educated can offer support at home after coming back from school, which can help children in their learning process compared to peers that do not receive this support.

Diverse and Tribal Language Component

Mohanty et al. (2009) analyze the relationship between the cycle of poverty and the language barrier in schools for tribal children in India, arguing that those factors are linked to capability deprivation, poor educational achievement and poor learning outcomes. This issue is exacerbated by both the fact that less than 1% of tribal children have instruction in their mother tongues, and by the content barrier, in which the daily life experiences and culture of tribal children are hardly present in textbooks and other curricular material in the dominant language schools. The authors, nevertheless, by analyzing the framework of the methodology of multilingual education programs (MLE), designed to promote multilingualism through education and preservation of societal diversity in Andhra Pradesh and Orissa, show that it provided a better quality of education in a second language, although systematic formative evaluation was a necessary condition to ensure effectiveness in mainstream schools.

Teacher Quality

India has the largest primary education system in the world, with over 200 million children. The Government of India has been investing in primary education, but some systemic inefficiencies, such as teacher absenteeism, present a relevant indicator of weak governance and are associated with poor educational performances across different states. Studies have found that reductions in student-teacher ratios are correlated with increased teacher absence in contexts with weak governance of education systems, and the increases in the frequency of school monitoring are strongly correlated with lower teacher absence. In that sense, increasing the frequency of monitoring is more cost-effective for increasing the student-teacher ratio than just hiring more teachers. (Muralidharan et al., 2017). However, it is important to note that increasing teacher attendance does not necessarily improve learning outcomes, as having someone in the room does not guarantee teachers putting in more effort or children engaging.

Besides absenteeism, Singh and Sarkar (2012) find that teaching practices like regularly checking homework, as well as factors such as the proximity of the teacher's residence to the school, teachers' attitudes towards the children, and teachers' perceptions of their schools, have emerged as important determinants of mathematics scores when comparing children from private and public schools. Another important factor shown is that the professional qualifications that a teacher has also resulted in significantly higher learning outcomes for students.

Access to School

The distance from school affects the enrollment of children in school in rural India. The closer the inhabitants of a community are to the school, the higher the chances of sending their children to school. Aggarwal (2018) argues that reducing the distance to school will not only encourage children's attendance, but it will also eliminate the time and resources spent to get to class. On the other hand, states involved in the construction of roads in rural India encourage school attendance among children under 14 years. However, those above that age are likely to drop out of school to embark on labor work to exploit the economic opportunities associated with infrastructural development (Aggarwal, 2018). This situation poses a challenge for educational attainment because even if children manage to finish primary-level education, learning often stops as children get older.

Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes Disadvantages

Studies found that most people from scheduled tribes (ST) and scheduled castes (SC) are illiterate, and among the literates, the majority have minimal educational attainment. This is a result of the stigma and discrimination they face in Indian society. They are treated as the lowest in the class categories. This dynamic affects the way people treat and associate with them. Many underprivileged learners have the capability, but situations and lack of facilities isolate them, particularly their children, from being enrolled in school, although the situation is gradually changing. The ST population stands far behind the general population in literacy rates, with low socioeconomic status and socio-cultural reasons acting as barriers to school enrollment specifically; poverty, illiteracy, ignorance, and fear kept the scheduled caste down in the society. (Maqbool and Akhter, 2019).

The influence of caste shapes nearly every dimension of economic and educational life in India. A child's caste often determines the type of school he attends, the treatment he receives from teachers, and how he interacts with peers. Even when students from marginalized castes succeed in entering higher education, their progress through the system and their prospects for securing government jobs remain strongly conditioned by caste-based advantage or discrimination. These structures continue into adulthood: job mobility frequently depends on caste networks, and assumptions about competence are filtered through caste identity. As Munshi (2019) notes, children from lower and tribal castes frequently face stigma and maltreatment and the scarcity of real opportunities. This may discourage children's motivation and effort in learning, as the perceived returns to education seem limited.

Beyond caste, aspiration failure further constrains educational effort. Ray (2006) describes this as occurring when an individual's "aspiration" window" meaning the group of people whose lives provide meaningful reference points, is so narrow that it offers no credible examples of upward mobility. People form aspirations by looking at those slightly ahead of them in social status; however, when the poor see few or no successful peers, the aspiration window collapses. Goals then become anchored to the limited outcomes visible in one's immediate surroundings rather than to one's true potential. In this context, low aspirations are not a reflection of ability or ambition but of social isolation and a lack of attainable role models. Ray argues that aspiration failure represents a socio-cognitive consequence of poverty: when success is not seen, it is not imagined, and when it is not imagined, it is never pursued.

Rural-urban Dimensions

Many children in tribal families usually drop out of school and do not finish the primary level education. Most of the children are forced to serve as laborers for economic reasons due to the poverty the family faces. In most cases, the tribal parents prefer sending boys to school while the girls offer labor work at home before getting married. Additionally, tribal families are often engaged in seasonal labor work; consequently, they travel to different places with their families, which causes the children to drop out of school (Rupavath, 2016). These constraints do not allow children to have permanent access or time to attend school regularly, impacting learning.

Gender Component

Many scholars have focused on how gender impacts school absenteeism and dropout rates in India. First, studies find that 40.8% of females missed school while they were menstruating, with the most common reasons being discomfort, anxiety, and inadequate facilities. Factors such as using unsanitary materials (e.g., cloth), lack of privacy in school facilities, and mothers' limited education contribute significantly to absenteeism. This is also associated with poor academic performance and difficulties in participating in school activities (Vashisht et al., 2018).

Second, Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups' girls encounter barriers that prevent them from accessing and continuing their education. Among the main barriers are low literacy levels, insufficient school infrastructure, a shortage of female teachers, and insecurity in residential schools. In addition, cultural perceptions and family economic priorities, such as domestic or agricultural work, limit girls' participation (Thamminaina et al., 2020).

Third, among girls, it was found that the main factors influencing absenteeism are economic, social, and school-related problems. Among those, poverty and labor migration are key factors contributing to school dropout, but cultural norms such as child marriage and the lack of importance given to girls' education, and the school environment, such as bullying and unsupportive learning environments, also play a major role (Prakash et al., 2017). As such, those barriers and constraints, whether social or contextual, also hamper educational achievement and learning outcomes.

Socioeconomic Status

Scholars show that poverty and education are correlated in both directions because financial limitations prevent people from receiving high-quality education, which in turn prevents them from finding work and developing the skills necessary to earn a living (Kapur, 2012). Building on this understanding of economic factors contributing to absenteeism, further research explores the broader relationship between socioeconomic status and truancy, highlighting that this impacts educational outcomes and is stratified by economic status. Sosu et al. (2021) found that students from families with lower economic status tend to be more absent. The study highlights that economic factors are more important in explaining truancy than social or cultural factors. The lack of quality education and the development of skills also affect the learning outcomes of those children, reinforcing the cycle of poverty and disadvantage they face.

Research has shown that social reproduction is intrinsically linked to the educational system and the distribution of capital (both cultural and economic), serving primarily to maintain existing class structures and power relations (Bourdieu, 1973). According to Bourdieu (1973), social reproduction, particularly in highly industrialized societies, is fundamentally maintained by the educational system, which functions to reproduce the existing distribution of cultural and economic capital across various social classes. This process is crucial because it ensures the perpetuation of the social masking of the hereditary transmission of power under an apparently neutral attitude but also guarantees the reproduction of the relations between the sections of the dominant classes.

Contributions of Family Duties and Domestic Labor to Low School Attendance and Poor Performance

Domestic labor, which is considered a category of child labor, is one of the factors contributing to low school attendance and poor academic performance. In many parts of India, the traditional family structure emphasizes economic contribution from children at a young age, prioritizing collective responsibility, leading to children working to support the family. Cultural norms and traditions, such as children engaging in the family business, perpetuate child labor, as skills are passed down through generations at the expense of formal education (Kumar, 2024).

Social pressure to conform to community expectations also reinforces this cycle, making breaking free from traditional practices difficult. Child labor is prevalent in agriculture, domestic chores, small-scale manufacturing, and street vending. The family unit is regarded as a suitable context for child labor, where family members influence the involvement of children in labor. These norms, deeply ingrained beliefs within a community, shape decisions about child labor within families. Parents believed that informal apprenticeship in family work provides future job security for children, compared to formal education. Due to the low job security arising from formal education, children are believed to be better off receiving an informal apprenticeship from their parents' occupations. The relative importance of informal apprenticeship training over formal education influences child labor practices (Abdullah et al., 2022). The results of such are twofold: engaging in child labor can result in poor academic performance and low learning outcomes, and it could also result in low school attendance or even drop out of school.

One study found that 18 percent of children aged 6 to 14 are not attending school because they are either working for the market or for the family. Age increases the probability of children working. Again, this effect is larger in rural areas. The number of other children aged 0 to 17 in the household reduces the probability of school attainment, especially male children aged 15 to 17, in rural areas, increasing the probability of inactivity by three percentage points (Abdullah et al., 2022).

Relationship between School Environment and Educational Outcomes

Several factors regarding the school infrastructure affect the possible educational outcomes of children, such as physical school infrastructure, resources, leadership aspects, teachers' skills and abilities, and classroom environment. The availability of physical school infrastructure is crucial for improving educational outcomes, such as enrollment and attendance. Long commutes to school can lead to fatigue and higher dropout rates among students. In India, the District Primary Education Program (1995–1999) focused on building schools, enrolling students, training teachers, and engaging communities. Districts involved in the program saw a significant improvement in learning outcomes and a 5.5–6% increase in primary school enrollment (Swaminathan, et al., 2020).

It is similarly crucial for schools to provide essential resources that enhance students' academic performance. Students from marginalized or socio-economically disadvantaged backgrounds often cannot afford learning materials and rely on libraries and their peers to access the necessary books and educational resources. School staff are entrusted with the responsibility of managing the school's operations, which include planning, organizing, controlling, and directing activities. Effective leadership in school administration plays a significant role in influencing student academic outcomes. Teachers play a key role in shaping students' academic performance and contribute to their overall development. Lastly, one of their primary responsibilities of teachers is to promote mutual understanding, friendliness, and cooperation among themselves and students. Effective classroom management leads to better organization of lesson plans, instructional strategies, and teaching-learning processes. When discipline and clear communication are maintained, students are more likely to learn effectively and improve their academic performance (Kapu, 2018).

Educational Governance Policies

India has implemented numerous education policies since its independence in 1947, aiming to improve educational outcomes, especially for marginalized groups. However, despite these efforts, India continues to lag East Asia and other global regions in educational achievement. Studies have shown that caste, religion, and rural location significantly impact educational attainment, with rural and marginalized groups facing the greatest barriers. Several policy interventions, such as universal education, have aimed to address these disparities, contributing to significant progress in educational access, as school attendance for children aged 6-14 increased from 85% in 1999-2000 to 96% in 2017-18, and learning outcomes, but gaps persist, particularly in educational attainment by gender and class (Bhattacharya, 2021).

Researchers find that while policy interventions have led to some improvements, they have not significantly reduced group-based educational inequalities. The rural-urban divide is especially pronounced, with rural females facing the most challenges. Regarding religious communities, although Muslim educational attainment has improved, it still lags compared to mainstream Hindus, particularly among the Scheduled Tribes and the Scheduled Castes (Varughese and Bairagya, 2020).

Comparison between Public and Private Schools

Numerous studies have found that private schools in India generally perform better than public schools, especially in terms of student achievement. The success of private schools can be attributed to better management practices and classroom strategies. Effective school management, especially in leadership and teacher retention, positively impacts learning outcomes. Specific teaching practices, such as checking notebooks and using textbooks, also contribute to better performance. Additionally, private schools often hire more teachers, maintaining a lower pupil-teacher ratio, which leads to more focused attention on students. Additionally, private schools tend to have longer school days compared to government schools, offering students more learning time. Most studies focus on school-related factors such as infrastructure and teacher quality, while less attention is given to home factors, such as time spent on homework and school attendance, which may also affect learning outcomes (Kumar and Choudhury, 2021).

3. BACKGROUND

3. BACKGROUND

ASPIRE is a registered non-profit organization working towards making education inclusive, socially relevant, and keeping pace with the 21st century challenges. It is a people's movement to ensure all children have the best possible learning opportunities and complete secondary schooling through a revitalized government school system. According to ASPIRE's annual report data, its household census survey conducted from July 2019 to April 2020 in Keonjhar district of Odisha found that among 128,275 children aged 6–18, 88.1 percent were enrolled in school, 4.3 percent had never enrolled, and 7.6 percent had dropped out. Dropouts are predominantly older youth, with 61 percent aged 15 or above, and girls are disproportionately affected, accounting for 58 percent of all dropouts. Among out-of-school children, 69 percent stay at home, 27 percent work, and 1.3 percent are in bonded labor. Key reasons for being out of school include child labor and household responsibilities affecting 39 percent of dropouts and 29 percent of never-enrolled children, financial barriers affecting 11 percent, learning deficits and loss of interest affecting 21 percent of dropouts, access challenges affecting up to 8 percent, and disability or illness affecting 4 to 8 percent (ASPIRE, 2020). These findings underscore the need for targeted remedial education, stronger family support, and improved access to schooling to provide children with opportunities to learn.

3.1 The Aspire Education Signature Program (ESP) Model

The ASPIRE Education Signature Program (ESP) is a comprehensive, large-scale initiative to provide equitable and quality education to children. The program currently covers nearly 1.5 million children (ages 3-16) across 5,900 schools and 7,125 Anganwadis in Odisha, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, and West Bengal. ASPIRE's strategy focuses on the coverage of an entire administrative unit, usually at a block or district level, to take advantage of all the administrative linkages in the block/district and work with all actors engaged in the education system.

The intervention is built around three key pillars and works on all three simultaneously. The Access pillar focuses on ensuring that every child is enrolled in school and progresses toward secondary completion (grade 10) by identifying out-of-school children and providing transitional education through Residential Bridge Courses (RBCs) and Non-Residential Bridge Courses (NRBCs) centers, as well as direct enrolment. These centers help children who have been out of school reintegrate into the formal education system. The RBCs provide full-time residential care and instruction for an extended period to children who need more intensive support. Additionally, ASPIRE uses Village Education Registers (VERs) to track enrollment and retention, leveraging community engagement to promote accountability and sustained access to education. ASPIRE undertakes house to house child census using digital App to assess status of children in 0-18 age group. This information is shared in the village council to sensitize the community, as well as to get the survey findings authenticated and endorsed. This endorsement is important to get the buy- in of the government bureaucracy, because these findings are often in variance with the information shared by the government. Planning for every child is done based on the information obtained from the child census.

The learning pillar focuses on addressing foundational skill gaps in reading, writing, and mathematics by promoting effective pedagogy, integrating transversal skills which happens more in middle schools; and strengthening the capacities of teachers and volunteers. A key component of this pillar is the Learning Enrichment Program (LEP), which aims to transform the learning environment in government schools. LEP introduces innovative approaches to teaching language, math, science, and social studies, embedding these methods within the government school system to prevent the early learning deficits that often emerge in grades 1 and 2. The program seeks to shift teachers' mindsets by demonstrating that poor learning outcomes often stem from unengaging teaching practices and pedagogical gaps, rather than from students themselves. ASPIRE's core activities include running specialized learning centers for demonstration and developing a cadre of well-trained educators, providing continuous training for LEP teachers and volunteers on effective classroom management, and developing teaching-learning materials (TLMs) to increase student participation and embed the new pedagogic practices in government schools by training and supporting government schoolteachers. Additionally, the program helps bridge the gap between home and school languages by incorporating local cultural practices, ensuring that learning is both inclusive and contextually meaningful.

The Governance pillar strengthens local ownership and accountability by empowering Gram panchayats, School Management Committees (SMCs), and community groups such as volunteers, Mothers' and Monitoring Committees to uphold children's rights to education. It engages with all sections of the community to bring change in the social norms in the society vis-à-vis children. ASPIRE collaborates with these bodies to improve the management of government schools and hostels and to prepare participatory development plans that reflect local priorities. Through capacity building and training, SMCs are equipped to monitor school performance, oversee grants, and develop School Development Plans (SDPs). The community actively implements universal access interventions such as weekly headcounts and attendance tracking to ensure that every child between the ages of 6 and 14 is enrolled and progressing in school. Together, these efforts strengthen local governance systems and promote community accountability.

ASPIRE's operations in Odisha, a state with a large tribal population, illustrates how the interaction of multiple issues hampers educational access and learning. Despite Odisha being a state rich in mineral resources, poverty, illiteracy, and social exclusion especially impact tribal populations in the area (Bindhani, 2021). This paradox of resource wealth and human deprivation shows that development benefits are not evenly distributed. Bindhani (2021) explains that economics, household work, a lack of interest in attending school, distance, and the language of instruction are some of the causes of school dropouts and absenteeism in the region. These interlinked barriers reveal that educational disadvantage in Odisha is a multidimensional problem, and addressing a single factor in isolation is unlikely to produce meaningful or sustained change in outcomes.

The role of language is particularly important. According to Kim et al. (2020), using unfamiliar languages in early grades is common in tribal and multilingual regions, and it hampers comprehension, oral language development, and overall reading acquisition. Although Kim et al. (2020) draw from aggregated data without a regional focus on India, their conclusions are relevant to Odisha because the state's tribal children face precisely the same multilingual environment described by the authors. In Odisha, tribal communities are the most affected, as children are taught in their native languages, but eventually the language of instruction used is Odia. This transition between home and school language often weakens literacy acquisition and contributes to early dropout.

3.2 Research Questions and Study Policy Contributions

The research project answers the research question “What are key enablers and barriers that explain variation in the establishment and sustenance of Universal Enrollment and Improving Learning Outcomes in the Keonjhar District, Odisha, India?”. This helps unpack the enabling factors and impeding obstacles that support or affect the successful implementation of ASPIRE programs. The factors could be social, governance, structural and geographic issues.

Findings will be used to propose evidence-based interventions and policy recommendations to strengthen ASPIRE’s ongoing initiatives and contribute to broader discussions on educational governance and equity in India and similar global contexts. This will help ASPIRE attain better outcomes in its educational initiatives by building on its strengths and improving on its gaps. The findings will help build a good background for replication of the strengths of ASPIRE’s educational program model in other parts of the world.

4. METHODOLOGY

4. METHODOLOGY

4.1 Methodology Overview

To achieve the project's goals, this study uses a qualitative multi-level multi-case approach, where supervisors and local stakeholders were targeted across six selected panchayats. Initially, quantitative data was used to select the panchayats based on the speed of attaining Child Labor Free Zone, showing variation among panchayats. However, since all selected panchayats achieved CLFZ status within a short window, these criteria did not provide meaningful differentiation. The project therefore used learning performance indicators to guide the selection of the panchayats focusing on the percentage of students that score below 40% on pre-tests and post-tests. From this, the project identified six relatively higher and lower powerforming panchayats.

After identifying six panchayats, the study engaged two levels of respondents. The first set of respondents are supervisors who oversee multiple panchayats. This approach was employed to understand broader program perspectives and cross-cutting implementation challenges. The second set of respondents are stakeholders in selected panchayats, including teachers, government officials, volunteers, community facilitators, etc. who have first-hand knowledge of the factors affecting learning in their respective areas. The study conducted semi-structured interviews with these two categories of respondents to identify the enablers and barriers that explain variation in learning outcomes in Keonjhar District. This design allows for both the understanding of performance differences and the exploration of contextual factors that influence educational achievement.

4.2 Sample Frame

The sample consists of three high-achieving and three low-achieving panchayats to help identify the key enablers and barriers that explain variation in the establishment and sustenance of Universal Enrollment and Improving Learning Outcomes in Keonjhar District, Odisha, India, along with ASPIRE staff who possess a strong understanding of the organization's interventions across varying contexts. Participants were selected to ensure a diverse sample of perspectives across the intervention structure. ASPIRE provided the list of participants who were interviewed, drawing from its existing networks and partnerships with School Management Committees, community education centers, and local government bodies.

The project engaged a total of 46 interviewees through 32 in-person and 16 virtual interviews. The in-person interviews primarily involved staff working on the ground implementation, while the virtual interviews targeted coordinators operating across 11 blocks. At the block level, the study focused on supervisors responsible for overseeing 3 to 5 panchayats each, as they provided system-wide perspectives on program execution, coordination challenges and variation in implementation quality. Within each panchayat, the interviews were conducted with community facilitators, members of school leadership, volunteers, representatives from the Child Rights Protection Forums and government representatives from both high- and low-achieving panchayats. These stakeholders were selected for their firsthand understanding of local education dynamics, including the community's engagement with schools, the functioning of support structures, and barriers affecting children's learning, specifically, they have hands-on experiences and understanding of the many issues and improvements that the ASPIRE intervention aimed to address, as they are stakeholders directly involved or affected by those processes. Their diverse perspectives offered a nuanced understanding of how contextual conditions either enabled or hindered progress in learning outcomes. Some interviews were conducted in pairs or small groups rather than individually, depending on participants' availability and context. These are people who implement or directly interact with ASPIRE interventions across the different panchayats. They have deep knowledge of the program benefits, challenges and opportunities that can be exploited for better outcomes.

Table 1. Sample Frame

<table>
<tr><th colspan="3">48 Interviews</th></tr>
<tr><th colspan="2">32 In-person</th><th>16 Virtual</th></tr>
<tr><td>3 Blocks</td><td>6 panchayats</td><td>11 Blocks</td></tr>
</table>

4.3 Data Collection

The study employed semi-structured interviews conducted in two formats, in-person and online interviews via zoom. Due to some logistical constraints, only two members of the project team made it to Odisha to conduct the data collection. They interacted with ASPIRE leadership at their Headquarters in New Delhi before moving to the field for interviews. The field team conducted all interviews in ASPIRE facilities to ensure accessibility and participant comfort. The virtual team on the other hand conducted virtual interviews using Zoom meetings with supervisors and block level coordinators, allowing engagement with participants based on different geographic locations. These participants were chosen for this mode of interview because of their accessibility to internet connectivity and other resources that the other participants might not have access to.

The semi-structured interview format allowed for flexibility while maintaining a focus on understanding the local factors influencing educational outcomes. This approach ensured that perspectives from both high and low-achieving panchayats were adequately captured, reflecting variations in local conditions and implementation practices.

4.4 Data Analysis

Data were analyzed using a systematic thematic approach. A codebook, an organized list of codes and their definitions used to guide consistent coding, was created in Excel, and a concept-cluster matrix, an analytical table that groups related ideas to show patterns and connections across themes, was utilized to map how the themes related to each other. Excerpts were hand-coded directly into the concept cluster matrix for each of the six panchayats to identify case-specific findings and for cross-case analysis, and one for the regional staff to elicit the perspectives of those with extensive knowledge of ASPIRE's work across a wider range of contexts.

Findings from the regional perspectives were first analyzed and synthesized to identify key themes, and then, in a second step, the high and low performing cases were analyzed in comparison with the emergent themes for their degree of support and alignment. The matrix was organized according to recurring themes and patterns categorized as enablers and barriers. Key themes identified include language barriers, parental education levels, poverty, caste and tribal discrimination, school accessibility, the role of government institutions, and the contributions of local authorities and volunteers to improve attendance and learning outcomes.

This analytical process enabled the research team to trace patterns across high- and low-achieving panchayats, identify recurring constraints, and highlight practices associated with sustained educational gains.

4.5. Limitations of the Study

This study faced some limitations that may have influenced its findings. First, during both in-person and virtual interviews, many participants did not speak or fully understand English and therefore communicated in their native languages. As a result, the study relied heavily on interpreters. This dependence introduces the possibility of translation errors, including omissions or interpretations that might not fully reflect the participants' original statements.

Secondly, some interviews were conducted in group settings under time constraints, which limited the ability of some participants to express their views in depth. Valuable insights may therefore have been condensed or left unmentioned.

Thirdly, the study focused on past ASPIRE interventions, therefore it did not capture recently introduced projects and programs.

Finally, because ASPIRE interventions were broad and geographically dispersed, it was not feasible to access all project sites. The study consequently concentrated on locations that were more easily accessible, which may affect the representativeness of the findings.

5. FINDINGS

5. FINDINGS

5.1 Strong Sources of Variability

The research detected seven clearly distinguished and regularly observed sources of variability that seem to significantly impact the outcomes of ASPIRE among panchayats. They are the factors that kept emerging in interviews and stories from the field as main considerations for the program's success. These comprise disparities in socioeconomic status, gaps in awareness and social reproduction, alcohol consumption and parental negligence, government participation, school leadership and accountability, and disparity in Learning Enrichment Program (LEP) accessibility. Each of these factors represent the overarching social and institutional issues that either facilitate or obstruct the capability of ASPIRE to efficiently achieve its educational aims.

5.1.1 Socioeconomic Status and Aspiration Failure

The Aspiration Failure is defined as when a person's "aspiration window", the social compass of people whose lives are noticeable and applicable is so narrow that it gives little reliable proof of progress, leading the individual to make goals far below their actual potential. Socioeconomic stability emerged as an apparently influential factor in shaping both children's access to education and the perceived effectiveness of ASPIRE's interventions. Economically well-off communities, nearer to block headquarters, and less affected by migration, like Gupuna, were reported to have shown more interest in education and be more likely to participate in and be responsive to ASPIRE's programming efforts. In contrast, more remote or poorer Gram panchayats (GPs) faced problems of poverty, child labor, and seasonal migration that made interventions less effective.

Counseling sessions, vocational training, and Community Education Resource Centers, are ASPIRE interventions that worked best in places where there was already a certain amount of social stability and strong community involvement. Families in these areas might take advantage of the chances these programs gave them, which let children re-enroll, learn useful skills, and even do something that would provide money to help pay for their studies.

The availability of engaged School Management Committee (SMC) members, Panchayati Raj Institution (PRI) officials, and successful students, was an important presence of visible role models since it made these interventions even more effective. panchayats reported to have higher proportions of educated and professional residents were reported to have more energetically taken up ASPIRE's interventions.

Respondents explained that communities with more educated role models in the community valued education more highly and supported strategies aimed at strengthening educational outcomes for children in the community. In contrast, the inputs of ASPIRE often had difficulties getting momentum or being taken up fully in communities with fewer well-educated community members, as there were no examples to serve as mental models for educationally induced social mobility.

A similar phenomenon was observed with more engaged leadership or communities with more social cohesion and norms of social participation. More engaged local community bodies and local governments tended to provide support that strengthened the implementation of ASPIRE programs and helped remove barriers and points of friction when they arose. For example, when a school would not allow a certain group of students to enroll in the school, a more engaged Grandpanch intervened in the school to correct the problem. With a less active or assertive Grandpanch, such barriers may have remained and impeded educational outcomes for student sub-groups.

So, based upon front-line stakeholder perceptions, it appears that the disparity in educational results across GPs may be linked to differences in economic ability, as well as inequalities in the density of social capital and the presence of role models. These appear to be key factors influencing how well ASPIRE's programs are taken up, implemented with fidelity, and thus lead to long-term educational engagement and achievement.

5.1.2 Social Reproduction and Awareness Gaps

Social Reproduction is intrinsically linked to the educational system and the distribution of capital (both cultural and economic), serving primarily to maintain existing class structures and power relations (Bourdieu, 1973). Deeply ingrained social inequalities and history of limited education access keep marginalized groups trapped in cycles of exclusion and low aspiration. In many places, especially from strong caste and tribal boundaries, families have internalized generations of being left out of education, which is often made worse by the institutions that are supposed to help them. A lot of people who answered the questions said that teachers and officials from outside the groups kept the stigma going by calling tribal or low-caste kids "unmotivated" or "incapable."

One powerful story came from a community facilitator working for ASPIRE. She talked about how she first met a headteacher who called tribal students "bad and unmotivated." Instead of confronting him directly, the staff started visiting families, encouraging parents and children to go to school regularly. They slowly showed the students' progress by showing how their attendance and performance were getting better. Over time, her determination changed the teacher's mind and made things better between the school and the tribal community.

In the same way, a Sarpanch told a story about a school that at first would not let kids from a certain caste group join. The Sarpanch stepped in through mediation and lobbying, using the right to education and demanding that all children, regardless of caste, be included. These cases show that discrimination in schools is often perpetuated by teachers from higher social groups who are actively keeping social inequality going.

Another interesting story came from an older woman who was a leader in one area and was known for breaking up underage weddings. She once took on a school that would not let kids from lower castes take their tests. Even though the community and the government were against her, she got the Child Rights Protection (CRPF) and panchayat members to demand responsibility. Her determination not only helped the kids take their tests, but it also got people in the neighborhood talking about discrimination and rights.

Even with these deep-seated inequities, ASPIRE's awareness campaigns, storytelling sessions, and community-based monitoring systems have been very important in changing how people think about these issues. ASPIRE helps make conversation, accountability, and inclusion a part of everyday life by focusing on local success stories and putting them in places like the Education Standing Committee and Child Rights Protection Forums (CRPFs). These venues have helped families on the margins see education as a right and a shared obligation, which has challenged traditional power structures and slowly broken down the cycle of educational inequity.

In this approach, awareness and empowerment are not only about getting information; they are actions that change the way power works in schools and communities, making sure that the next generation has fewer problems because of their caste, class, or tribal identity.

5.1.3 Alcohol Consumption and Insufficient Parental Support

Although less frequently cited, alcohol consumption - especially adulterated alcohol - among parents in certain tribal-dominated areas emerges as a barrier that interacts with both socioeconomic constraints and limited social role models. Even where families recognize the value of education, alcohol-related abuse can reduce parental involvement, undermine monitoring of attendance, and compromise children's learning environments. This adulterated alcohol abuse in some panchayats involves alcohol being laced with toxic substances, such as rat poison and urea, to make the effects stronger, but also far more dangerous. Additionally, methanol is sometimes added to increase the perceived strength of the alcohol; however, once ingested, it is metabolized into formaldehyde and formic acid, which can cause blindness, organ failure, and even death (Methanol Institute, 2016).

Respondents from the Munda and Juanga communities described widespread alcohol use as a direct element of parental neglect, poor supervision, and irregular school attendance. ASPIRE staff even reported safety concerns when conducting outreach in these villages: "*Once they drink, it is difficult for us to deal with them, and our staff get scared to go to those places.*"

Although not universal, this issue has a disproportionate impact on affected communities, undermining efforts to sustain attendance and engagement. Recognizing the problem, ASPIRE and School Management Committees (SMCs) have initiated awareness campaigns and home visits, leading to modest but visible improvements in parental discipline and participation. In some areas, communities have begun to set informal rules against excessive drinking, reflecting early signs of collective responsibility for children's education.

Ultimately, alcohol consumption remains a critical barrier to educational equity; its persistence in certain communities continues to limit the effectiveness of even well-structured interventions, underscoring the need for integrated social health and education strategies.

5.1.4 Government Engagement

Some respondents directly linked strong government engagement with the high performance of certain panchayats. They emphasized that when local government actors particularly Sarpanches and members of panchayat-level committees take active roles in education, schools function more effectively and inclusively. Several respondents referenced the presence of government forums and regular review mechanisms that support children's education and welfare.

In addition to these formal structures, the responsiveness and initiative of individual leaders often made a decisive difference. Respondents repeatedly highlighted Panchayats where the Sarpanch and education standing committees were highly active mobilizing resources, coordinating with ASPIRE staff, and resolving school-level challenges. As one participant recounted:

> *The children named Raju Ho and Birsa Ho of Kebalipal panchayat, who were child laborers as well as orphans, were supported with the help of stakeholders. We kept them in RBC and gave them basic education. The Sarpanch wrote a letter to the Child Welfare Committee and made a settlement that they can avail free education till higher secondary in Omkar Sevasharam. At present, they are in 9th grade and continuing their education.*

This example illustrates how committed local leadership, combined with ASPIRE's community-based model, can bridge systemic gaps and ensure inclusion of marginalized children who might otherwise be left out of the education system.

A particularly striking illustration from the field involved a Sarpanch who personally intervened in a local school to confront discriminatory practices. During fieldwork, the Sarpanch discovered that the head teacher was preventing children from a marginalized tribal group from enrolling. Recognizing the violation of the Right to Education norms, the Sarpanch convened an emergency meeting with ASPIRE facilitators, SMC members, and the Panchayat Education Standing Committee. Through collective pressure, the Sarpanch compelled the head teacher to admit the children, ensuring their full participation in school activities. This incident not only underscores the power of local accountability but also demonstrates how ASPIRE's coordination mechanisms empower village leaders to uphold educational rights in practice.

Across multiple interviews, respondents described similar dynamics where active and informed local officials leveraged existing governance forums to improve infrastructure, monitor attendance, and strengthen inclusion. Panchayats with strong, engaged leadership tended to rank higher in ASPIRE's internal assessments, largely because such leaders could mobilize both state resources and community networks. Conversely, areas with inactive or uninformed governance bodies struggled to sustain ASPIRE's interventions once external facilitation decreased.

Taken together, these findings affirm that local political will and governance responsiveness are critical enablers of ASPIRE's success. The combination of motivated Sarpanchs, functioning education standing committees, and cross-sectoral forums (such as CRPFs and Girls' Rights Protection Forums) forms a local governance ecosystem that magnifies ASPIRE's reach.

5.1.5 School Leadership and Teacher Accountability

Respondents consistently identified school leadership as a critical factor mediating teacher behavior and performance. Panchayats ranked as high performing typically featured proactive headmasters and active School Management Committees (SMCs) that enforced accountability through regular meetings and oversight. As one respondent summarized: *"I think two things made the block number one: school leadership and community engagement."* Another one elaborated:

> *It is not only community engagement but also school leadership and learner readiness. Attendance and retention have increased, and SMC meetings are usually conducted every month. They discuss teaching methods in class and how to enable all the teachers so that children can learn efficiently.*

This finding suggests that the success of ASPIRE's interventions is closely tied to the strength of school leadership and the functionality of School Management Committees. Where headmasters and SMCs actively promote accountability and collaboration, ASPIRE's programs are more likely to achieve sustained improvements in teacher performance, attendance, and student learning. Conversely, in areas with weaker leadership structures, the initiative's effectiveness may be constrained by limited oversight and reduced teacher engagement.

5.1.6 Learning Enrichment Program (LEP) Coverage and Training Demand

Several respondents highlighted the Learning Enrichment Program (LEP) as a major driver of improved learning outcomes, though its implementation varied widely across sites. One respondent attributed Kumundi's stronger performance compared to Phuljhar directly to LEP coverage:

> *In Kumundi, the LEP (Learning Enrichment Program) classes have been running from the beginning. These classes helped children gain foundational knowledge and develop*

learning habits. Older children often transfer their knowledge to their siblings, further reinforcing learning within the family.

This observation suggests that the LEP, when introduced early and supported consistently, played a critical role in developing foundational skills and learning continuity. However, the comparative reference to Phuljhar underscores a key source of variation, not all schools or communities benefited from LEP-trained teachers or the same level of implementation support.

Our findings suggest that this selective allocation of LEP teachers and training resources, likely driven by logistical and administrative constraints, could have an effect in variation in learning environments across panchayats. It was suggested that schools that received dedicated LEP teachers and regular ASPIRE support sessions showed measurable improvements, while others, left without this input, lagged.

Field accounts suggest that ASPIRE prioritized certain schools, on their ability to cover a larger number of habitations and where children showed slow learning levels and higher need, aiming for the schools to be shown as a demo easily to others. However, the transfer of pedagogical approaches proved limited in practice. Remote schools with teacher shortages, that also lacked both trained staff and follow-up training sessions, struggled to replicate LEP methodologies, leaving the intervention’s benefits localized and site-specific. The following teacher’s comment further illustrates the demand for deeper engagement and training support:

> *I want full-time support from ASPIRE staff. If I get more time from them, then I can teach the children in a better way, make more TLMs, and clear more of the children’s doubts. In the training, if we could make more TLMs, that would be very helpful. I want subject-wise TLM-making, so that we can teach properly. Even though we have some TLMs, they are not sufficient. If I get more support in making more TLMs, it will help a lot.*

These accounts reveal that where LEP teachers and structured training were present, the program worked as intended, enhancing teacher capacity, classroom engagement, and student learning that was also assisted by the work of local volunteers. Yet, its inability to transfer effectively to other schools without such direct inputs explains the persistent variation in outcomes across regions, showing the remoteness issue and the lack of human resources in those areas.

5.2. Potential Sources of Variability and Barriers to Learning and Access

In addition to well-established drivers, the study identified several probable but less clear sources of variability. In other words, there is clear evidence that stakeholders perceive the following to be barriers to educational outcomes, but it is less clear whether these are also sources of variability in intervention effectiveness. They are contextual or operational factors that appear to influence outcomes but are not consistently evident across all study sites. Their influence may nonetheless be significant in shaping disparities in access and learning, particularly in hard-to-reach and linguistically diverse communities, and we suggest they are worthy of additional investigation.

5.2.1 Degree of Remoteness, Teacher Shortages, and Unequal Ratios

Teacher absenteeism and poor instructional quality emerged as among the most frequently cited barriers to ASPIRE's success, but their intensity varied sharply by geography. Regarding earlier years of the intervention, a respondent observed:

> *In accessible areas, children attend school regularly, but in interior areas, schools are often closed, or teachers are absent. Teaching quality is poor, and children do not get proper guidance.*

This distinction between "accessible" and "interior" contexts reveals one of the most persistent patterns of variability uncovered in the study. Whereas ASPIRE's leadership initially emphasized uniform implementation across panchayats, field evidence suggests that the degree of *remoteness,* particularly in jungle and tribal regions, could have an effect on the program's outcomes. Several interviewees had a perception that teachers in these areas are less motivated:

> *Teachers in high-ranked areas easily understand our process, align with the objectives, and implement activities very easily. In the jungle areas, teachers are very lazy and cannot grasp the concepts, as the government has chosen very lazy persons for those areas.*

These accounts show the respondents' perception that ASPIRE's overall effectiveness depends not only on program design but also on the local state's direct involvement and teacher commitment to mediate implementation on the ground. Remote contexts appear to exacerbate systemic weaknesses, poor infrastructure, and isolation that reduce accountability and weaken teacher engagement. Consequently, ASPIRE's interventions, while conceptually strong, may yield inconsistent results, which could depend on differing implementation capacity in local contexts.

Beyond motivational differences, a chronic shortage of government teachers are perceived to compound these disparities. This issue was mentioned in seven interviews, most often concerning tribal or interior panchayats. One participant stated:

> *Gram Sabhas are conducted monthly in each village, where SMC members raise concerns about teacher shortages, teaching quality, mid-day meal issues, and children's regularity.*

Despite such venues for advocacy, respondents described minimal responsiveness from higher authorities. A field coordinator from a tribal block lamented:

Even if children want to go to school, there are not enough teachers. In seven schools, there are only three or four teachers. So even if children attend school during the day, they cannot get a proper education. As a result, they feel bored and become unwilling to go to school.

The shortage forces teachers to teach multi-grade classes, which can be challenging, or causes teacher-to-student ratios to exceed the limits set by the Right to Education (RTE) norms. As one Block Learning Coordinator noted: *"According to the RTE 2009, one teacher should oversee 30 students. However, sometimes one teacher handles classes from grades 1 to 5 at the same time because there are not enough teachers in the school."*

Taken together, these findings suggest stakeholder perception that remoteness amplifies inequities in teacher allocation, supervision, and morale, resulting in variable underlying constraint by context and potentially mediating differences in ASPIRE's on-the-ground impact. Stakeholder responses suggest that the program's success in accessible areas differs from its effectiveness in jungle and tribal contexts, where the state's logistical reach and teacher incentives are weakest. Nevertheless, since based on individual perceptions that are also tied to regional realities, these factors were not uniformly mentioned by the interviewees of similar backgrounds, but nevertheless were deemed relevant for consideration. While there is evidence that ASPIRE already adopts differentiated strategies that account for contextual differences, the question of differential treatment is worth ongoing consideration, such as targeted teacher incentives, digital learning supports, or community-based para-teacher schemes to ensure equitable outcomes across diverse geographies.

5.2.2 Degree of Language Match

Some respondents mentioned that many teachers struggle to teach children because they cannot speak their local language. One of them highlighted that:

One major challenge is language. In Anganwadis, teachers use Odia, but many children speak tribal languages like Munda or Ho. This language gap creates a barrier between teachers and children. Language differences significantly affect learning outcomes and school participation.

Additionally, some respondents mentioned that some teachers have other primary languages and may be less interested in communicating with children from other languages. One of the respondents highlighted that children whose parents migrated to other places for work and returned to Odisha struggle with the Odia language, as they were not exposed to it. Some of the respondents mentioned that the volunteer program, where locals and staff taught teachers their native language, helped to bridge the teacher-children language gap. A Bridge Language Inventory (BLI) app was developed by ASPIRE and recommended to teachers to bridge this gap, but it was not mentioned in the interview responses.

Language barriers may limit the reach and impact of its educational activities, specially in multilingual and tribal areas. When teachers and students do not share a common language, key components of the program, such as classroom engagement, instructional quality, and learning outcomes, are weakened, although there are efforts by ASPIRE and teachers to address it. This may suggest that some of the variability of ASPIRE's implementation could be affected by the level of linguistic mismatch between students, teachers and other stakeholders, although it was not uniformly observed in the interviews across panchayats and levels.

5.3. Individual-Level Barriers

While structural and contextual factors explain much of the variability across panchayats, individual-level constraints also play a critical role in shaping educational trajectories. These personal and household circumstances interact with broader systemic inequities, often determining whether children can sustain participation in school despite ASPIRE's interventions.

5.3.1 Students' Age

Interviewees consistently highlighted that children who are older and enrolled in higher grades face significant challenges in transitioning to and remaining in school. Factors such as financial constraints, lack of nearby schools offering higher grades, and increasingly difficult curricula were cited as major deterrents. Noting the initial size of the issue the respondent explained:

> *Due to a lack of seats in the college, securing fewer marks, being unable to study in faraway places, and poverty are reasons to discontinue their higher studies. Children mainly drop their classes when they transition from primary school to middle school and from middle school to high school, and from high school to higher secondary school.*

While these issues might appear to be general barriers to educational progression, they have specific implications for ASPIRE's capacity to sustain engagement among older students. ASPIRE's core interventions such as foundational learning support, counseling, and community mobilization showed signs of being highly effective in re-engaging younger children and promoting early-grade attendance. However, the program's design was perceived to be less equipped to address the distinct motivational, financial, and logistical challenges that arise as children progress to higher grades.

As students age, the perceived opportunity costs of schooling increase, and ASPIRE's learning and incentive structures often may not - based upon stakeholder perceptions - be adequately robust to support the majority of older students' educational attainment through and beyond upper secondary school. In remote panchayats, where secondary schools are located far from villages and transportation is limited, even motivated students face structural barriers to continuation, although there are community demands to the state government for higher secondary schools that are being implemented gradually. Despite efforts by ASPIRE to facilitate access to government scholarships and providing private financial assistance to nearly 100 students for higher education, scholarships for older students, transition counseling, or partnerships with vocational programs remain limited. This means that ASPIRE's gains at the primary level may be difficult to sustain beyond upper secondary school. Additional reporting and tracking of this data would also be valuable.

This pattern highlights a possible opportunity for growth in ASPIRE's engagement strategy to bolster educational support for students through later stages of schooling. The program was initially designed for children between 6 and 14 years, and it was later expanded to include children aged 14 to 16, with interventions for older children being in place for fewer years compared to interventions for younger children. It appears that relatively little support is provided beyond age 16 for post-secondary matriculation and workforce readiness and facilitation. Ensuring that the program's achievements in foundational learning translate into long-term educational attainment is an area to consider additional inputs and investment.

5.3.2 Caste and Tribal System

A few interviewees mentioned the existing government bodies and forums that hold meetings with local stakeholders to discuss issues related to education, with community empowerment as a key factor for demanding improvements for education to the government, as well as governmental schemes that support people with lower incomes. Both of those elements are presented differently when it comes to people from caste or tribal communities. Regarding factors influencing low-performing panchayats, it was said:

> *The first factor is a high tribal population, about 96% of the population is tribal [...] People have low confidence to stand in front of government officials and feel inferior to educated people, so they are afraid to ask for their rights.*

Some interviewees mentioned that certain castes and communities do not qualify for government support, and they also suggested a perceived sense of inferiority and lack of empowerment among the tribal and caste populations, as well as a general unawareness and lack of education within those communities.

The success of ASPIRE's interventions may be constrained in contexts where caste dynamics, and limited community empowerment reduce local participation and accountability. When communities, particularly those from tribal or marginalized castes, lack confidence or awareness to engage with government bodies, the sustainability and reach of ASPIRE's efforts can be weakened, as active community involvement is essential for driving educational demand and reinforcing institutional responsiveness. There is already an effort of ASPIRE to motivate and empower those communities, although social norms and practices persist within some communities.

5.3.3 Daily Wage-earning Parents

The issue of daily wage labor emerged frequently across interviews as a barrier to children's education. Respondents explained that parents often prioritize earning income over schooling, viewing children's participation in family work as more immediately valuable than attending classes. In many households, parents' long working hours and frequent absences reduce their engagement in their children's education and limit participation in community meetings or awareness programs. As one interviewee noted: "*In interior GPs, people are busy with daily wage work from morning till evening. They are hardly available to attend meetings or listen to new ideas, which limits progress".*

In more severe cases, economic pressure contributes to domestic child labor, where children take on household responsibilities or care for siblings, while some families face additional challenges, such as alcoholism, which further disrupts children's learning and community coordination.

These conditions mitigate ASPIRE's effectiveness by weakening community participation and parental involvement, which are two elements central to ASPIRE's programs and theory of change. When economic survival takes precedence over schooling, ASPIRE's outreach and mobilization efforts face limitations in achieving long-term behavioral and attitudinal change toward education. Their model highlights collective wisdom and social pressure from the community to ensure no children are left out. In communities where individuals or parents may not be able to attend meetings regularly, communities are responsible for ensuring children's attendance and continuation in schools. However, feedback from front-line respondents indicates that low parental engagement may still be a barrier, and it is worth exploring whether the social pressure model is an adequate work around or if additional support may be warranted.

6. RECOMMENDATIONS

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6.1 Leverage Local Role Models to Address Aspiration Failure

ASPIRE and local education stakeholders should formalize engagement programs that draw on educated youth, alumni, and community volunteers, especially first-generation graduates from nearby successful Gram panchayats to serve as visible role models. Their participation in school events and career workshops can inspire families and students in marginalized areas, demonstrating the tangible outcomes of continued education, helping break cycles of low aspirations. To further normalize educational continuation and increase parental and community buy-in, these efforts should be complemented by sharing local success stories to deliver motivational talks in schools and meetings.

Morgenroth et al. (2015) define that role models can work in three different ways with varying outcomes: by embodying a role of an aspirant's already existing goals by having high levels of success or goal-related competence the aspirant's expectancy and motivation increases, also likely leading to skill acquisition; by representing "the possible", having a shared group membership or similarity it increases the aspirant's motivation to move toward an existing or adopt a new goal, therefore changing the aspirants' self-stereotyping and perceived barriers; and by inspiring, being perceived as desirable by the aspirant, resulting in identification, internalization, and admiration, contributing to aspirants adopting new goals and influencing the value placed on a goal.

Bhan (2020), in return, shows experimental evidence on the significance of role models in fostering hope, increasing effort, and improving the academic performance of primary school students in Jaipur, Rajasthan, India. The treatment consisted of a set of three short films depicting children of the region who find inspiration in opportunities and role models to pursue a goal and have successful outcomes, finding significant improvements in students' self-efficacy and happiness, with a cost-effective treatment intervention tool by using role models to influence student motivation and their learning outcomes.

6.2 Address Social Illness through Community-based Alcohol Awareness Campaigns

To mitigate the impact of alcohol addiction - and particularly the dangers of adulterated alcohol consumption - on parental involvement and children's schooling, ASPIRE should collaborate with panchayat leaders, SMCs, and local health workers to design culturally sensitive campaigns focused on alcohol prevention, the particular dangers of adulterated alcohol, and rehabilitation. Activities may include village dialogues, family counseling, and youth clubs, helping to foster healthier home environments that support consistent school attendance and learning. Mosher and Jernigan (1988) argue that efforts to change the drinking behavior of individuals have failed because institutional messages are not aligned with public health messages, thus prevention efforts should include changing the institutional environment around alcohol, by translating and disseminating research through action-oriented informational resources such as seminar, conferences and workshops, designating and training of leaders, and creating issue-oriented coalitions, at the grassroot level. Furthermore, Booth et al. (2023) by analyzing a campaign in Western Australia to inform people about the carcinogenic properties of alcohol and associated harms, suggest that the provision of information about the alcohol-cancer link has the potential to motivate reduced alcohol consumption effectively.

6.3. Addressing Age-Related Barriers: Mentorship for Older Students

To sustain engagement and support older students who face age-related barriers, ASPIRE should focus on exploring and implementing additional inputs for older students. A particularly cost-effective approach worth exploring is a mentorship program. While ASPIRE should rely on alumni or community members as mentors whenever possible, the availability of such individuals is often limited because most learners in ASPIRE’s operational areas are first-generation students. In many villages, there are few people who have progressed beyond secondary school or entered formal employment, which restricts the local pool of potential mentors. Consequently, ASPIRE may need to bring in educated graduates or volunteers from nearby towns or partner institutions to ensure consistent, structured support for older or at-risk students. These mentors would guide pupils on motivation, effective study habits, and professional aspirations, while their ongoing interactions with students can foster a stronger commitment to schooling, encouraging learners to persist not only through high school but also to ASPIRE toward higher education through exposure and aspiration.

Simultaneously, the program should integrate career guidance workshops, including vocational training sessions that outline clear educational and employment pathways and help students develop actionable plans for higher education. To ensure the initiative's effectiveness, ASPIRE field coordinators should implement a system of tracking and support, monitoring mentees monthly to assess satisfaction, measure progress, and identify areas where additional guidance may be needed.

Ehrich et al. (2004) analyze different studies on mentoring in different areas, specifically in education, and conclude that mentoring resulted in both personal and emotional support, career development, and satisfaction providing skills, access to new ideas, and personal growth for both mentees and mentors. Some of the challenges found and that are worth considering in the process are the lack of time and training, but also personal or professional incompatibility

6.4 Enhancing School Leadership

ASPIRE should prioritize enhancing school leadership to strengthen local institutional effectiveness and accountability. Although peer-learning exchanges and structured exposure visits between high- and low-performing Gram panchayats to facilitate the direct sharing of practical leadership and governance strategies are included in the program’s formal design, field respondents did not mention these initiatives when prompted during interviews. This may indicate that, despite being part of the formal plan, these activities may not be implemented consistently or are not sufficiently visible to frontline staff. Strengthening this component and ensuring that field teams clearly understand and engage with it may strengthen systematic leadership learning across Gram panchayats as a core lever of quality improvement in schools.

A complementary strategy involves studying and codifying effective leadership practices for training others. This requires capturing the experiences, skills, and decision-making approaches of high-performing school leaders, organizing them into a clear framework, and transmitting this knowledge through methods such as case studies, mentorship, and simulations. Such codification creates a shared language and a repeatable model of success within the program. To reinforce accountability through visibility, ASPIRE already encourages school leaders to share operational challenges, progress indicators, and achievements in community meetings; however, respondents expressed that these practices should occur more frequently and more systematically. Finally, dedicated capacity building is essential: while ASPIRE has a training program worked out in collaboration with the government, respondents expressed a desire for these sessions to occur more frequently, emphasizing the value of continuous, progress-focused support that equips SMC members to address emerging challenges, strengthen areas of strong performance, and respond to evolving school needs.

Huber (2004) looks at the central role of school leadership for developing and assuring the quality of schools defining leadership as adjusted to the core purpose of school, and based on educational beliefs integrating the values of a democratic society, by making it legitimate in society and to those who are “led”, and aligned with the beliefs of encouraging maturity, practicing acceptance, supporting autonomy and realizing cooperation. In addition, Andreoli et al. (2020) by examining the growth of 10 leaders from rural schools who participated in a 3-year research–practice partnership called the Leadership Learning Community (LLC), where they participated in 12 day-long professional development sessions facilitated by university faculty and job-embedded coaching sessions at the leaders’ schools, showed that leaders grew in involving and interacting differently with others for shared effort and ownership, enabling distributed leadership for increased capacity, using a systematic process for school improvement, and approaching school improvement with a new mindset.

6.5. Restoring the Volunteer Learning Program

The initial purpose of the LEP was to demonstrate that, with effective pedagogic interventions, children who had remained illiterate and were irregular in school could learn and enjoy learning. As many government schools have now adopted these pedagogic practices, the demonstrative role of the LEP is no longer required. In the current model, government teachers primarily receive classroom support from volunteers rather than from LEP teachers, and teachers consistently reported that this volunteer support is highly valuable. Thus, the volunteer program should continue to operate, perhaps requiring additional strengthening to ensure that volunteers can provide consistent, high-quality pedagogic assistance.

To ensure that, ASPIRE should establish a volunteer-teacher model focused on the FLN program, where they can train local volunteer teachers who rotate across a group of nearby government schools to support younger students in basic reading and numeracy. Mentors can run small FLN practice groups, model simple learning activities, and encourage regular attendance, giving students relatable support while reinforcing foundational skills. Valls and Kyriakides (2013) explore the use of Interactive Groups (IGs), that is the grouping of students heterogeneously and the inclusion of adults from the community in the classroom to address educational inequalities and enhance learning, showing that that IGs are one of the most successful inclusive actions initiatives that can be implemented in schools. In conclusion, this teacher-volunteer approach of ASPIRE should continue their practical and straightforward approach of training and cooperation aiming at the support of children based on their individual characteristics, needs and challenges.

7. CONCLUSION

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Stakeholders in the sampled schools and communities report that ASPIRE's Education Signature Program has had a profoundly meaningful impact on the lives of the population in Odisha, particularly in the Keonjhar District. The combination of efforts towards Access, Learning, and Governance demonstrates the complex and deep nature of the barriers affecting secondary education and learning quality in this region, as well as the strength of the program's implementation, despite these structural issues.

Namely, the universal enrollment achievement and improving learning outcomes highlight the importance of the interventions in engaging the different stakeholders and ensuring that children are enrolled and attending schools. Achieving this status also encompasses the restructuring of learning interventions and the motivation of different relevant stakeholders to participate actively in the defense of education and children's rights.

The initial literature review and consequent research design of this I-lab project sought to explore the variability in the results between blocks and panchayats, especially on learning gains, aiming to help uncover the different factors that could act as barriers or enablers to learning outcomes. Therefore, the methodology applied aimed to select the blocks, and more specifically the panchayats, that demonstrated this variation of results across a diverse set of characteristics (urban, tribal, and a combination of both).

The findings and recommendations highlighted in this report demonstrate that ASPIRE's interventions are important and meaningful in changing mindsets, empowering communities, and ensuring children's rights to education, alongside the many stakeholders involved in this process. The effort is robust, and the strategy encompasses a multitude of fronts that are stronger and more efficient when developed together. Nevertheless, the implementation design could allow for a more flexible approach to deal with individual and unique characteristics of certain panchayats and communities, to ensure that their barriers are properly addressed and that they are not left behind.

As per our Theory of Change, we aimed at identifying key enablers and barriers to the establishment and sustenance of universal enrollment and to students improving learning outcomes, to recommend evidence-based interventions to address the barriers, with the goal that children's enrollment in school will be increased, high attendance rates will be maintained, and there will be improved learning outcomes. This report also aims to support future research, interventions, and evaluations, with the ultimate goal of ensuring that the ASPIRE efforts increase their reach and continue to develop the future of these children and communities.

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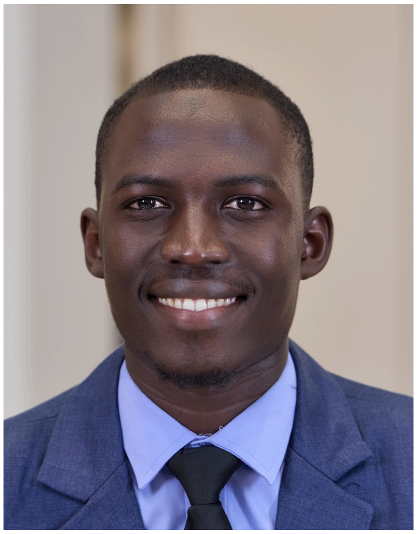

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